

WhatsApp - One-to-one messaging

How to & best practices

Context

A Store Associate needs to:

- Proactively contact an assigned client.
- Continue a personal one-to-one relationship.
- Let the client easily reach their preferred SA.

Today, some SAs initiate conversations from newly configured WhatsApp accounts through the Clienteling App. These accounts may be temporarily restricted, sometimes after the first outbound message.

Why WhatsApp may flag some outreach messages

WhatsApp automatically analyses account behaviour and can restrict activity that resembles spam, automated messaging or bulk outreach.

The tested pattern looks suspicious to WhatsApp:

- new WhatsApp account/device
- no / few previous conversation
- business initiates contact directly
- “templated” message or message triggered from another application

The message itself may be legitimate and personalised. The problem is the **pattern**, which resembles commercial prospecting / spam.

WhatsApp officially confirms that it uses automated processing to review account behaviour and enforce its messaging rules:

- [WhatsApp Messaging Guidelines](#)
- [Temporary account restrictions](#)

A new device, an unsaved contact or stricter APAC enforcement may contribute, but WhatsApp does not officially confirm the blocking rules.

How are brands leveraging Whatsapp ecosystem

There are multiple approaches to 1 to 1 outreach and chats with customers. The answer might be multiple (example: company provided “personal” SA account for 1 to 1 discussion with VIC, and business platform / chat function in the clienteling app for

Using the SA’s personal account / phone number

Company provides each SA with:

- A dedicated phone number/SIM
- A company-managed device

When to use and how to use

- For a client or VIC to stay in close contact with an SA
- Best if the customer should initiate the discussion
- Avoid templated messages, SA communicates naturally with the customer
- Use this model **only** for genuine, ongoing VIC-to-SA relationships - not for campaigns or systematic outbound prospecting

When the client initiates the conversation:

- This is the best practice to avoid one account constantly being the first to reach out
- To avoid restrictions, try to get the client to start the conversation when possible (scan SA QR Code), client writes the first message

When the SA initiates the conversation:

- The client should reasonably expect the message (avoid the client reporting the account as spam / blocking the account)
- The SA should clearly identify themselves and the store to avoid being blocked

Example: “Hello Marie, this is Eva from the Ralph Lauren Sheung Wan store. You asked me to contact you when the new collection arrived”

Limitations

- Regular WhatsApp Messenger is intended for personal use, its terms prohibit non-personal use unless authorised by WhatsApp
- Company ownership of the SIM does not protect the account from spam detection
- Repetitive, templated or unwanted outreach may still trigger restrictions
- There is no central supervision, CRM integration or company-wide consent management
- Each SA account operates independently
- No SA reassignment mechanism

WhatsApp explicitly prohibits repeated unwanted contact and may use automated account-behaviour analysis to detect potential spam. [WhatsApp Guidelines](#)

Using the WhatsApp Business App:

The Whatsapp business app is a free mobile application designed for small businesses. It works like normal WhatsApp but adds:

- A business profile
- Greeting and away messages
- Quick replies
- Labels to organise conversations
- Product catalogues
- QR codes and short links

It uses one WhatsApp phone number and one shared inbox. [WhatsApp for Business](#)

Can multiple SAs share one account?

The main phone registers the account, then additional SAs access the **same account** through linked devices (up to 4 to 10 linked devices - need a meta verified account to go up to 10 “multi-agent” mode: [About multi agents](#)).

Limitations

All SAs **operate under the same store identity** and generally see the same conversations. The Business App is not designed for sophisticated enterprise clienteling:

- Limited client-to-SA assignment
- No native CRM integration
- Risk of two SAs answering the same customer
- Weak tracking of ownership and performance
- Difficult to manage across many stores and SAs

WhatsApp itself positions the Business App for small businesses and recommends the Business Platform for larger multi-user organisations requiring integration, scale and tracking.

Can we create one business app account per SA?

This is technically feasible, so each SA would have:

- One unique company-owned phone number
- One independently registered WhatsApp Business App account
- One company-managed device

Limitations

But for 500 SA, it would mean this would be 500 separate accounts. WhatsApp provides no central account / tenant, administrator console or API management across those business app accounts, so this is not scalable for medium to large scale operations.

Using the WhatsApp Business Platform

The WhatsApp Business Platform is the Meta recommended solution for a large retailer with many stores and SAs. It is an API, not a mobile application or shared WhatsApp inbox. It connects WhatsApp to the brand's Clienteling App or CRM. Meta positions it for 1 to many messaging, CRM integration, and conversations handled by human or automated agents. [About whatsapp business platform](#)

In principle this is a one-to-many messaging platform, but the API can be leveraged to do some one to one (as long as the customer has been active within a 24h window).

How it works

- The customer sees an official brand or store WhatsApp number.
- Each SA works from the Clienteling App, not from a shared phone.
- The Clienteling App identifies the customer and routes the conversation to their assigned SA.
- The SA writes personally and can introduce themselves by name.
- The conversation history remains owned by the retailer if the SA changes store or leaves.
- The client-to-SA assignment is managed by the Clienteling App, not by WhatsApp.

Starting conversations

- Customer starts: The customer scans the SA's QR code or clicks "Chat with my advisor." The Clienteling App routes the message to that SA.

- SA starts: The customer must have opted in. Outside an active 24-hour conversation window, the SA must use an existing WhatsApp business platform template. Once the customer replies, the SA can continue with normal free one-to-one messages through the Clienteling App.

Limitations

- Whatsapp does not provide any client -> SA binding mechanism, this should be built by the brand
- Whatsapp does not provide any API to get an SA ID out of a customer first contact
 - What can be done: The client scans a QR Code that opens the brand business account with a “prefill” message
 - The prefill message contains the SA ID, the API catches the prefilled message and extract the SA ID to bind it to the customer ID
- Brand need to build their own outreach system & inbox / chat system in the clienteling app, connected to the whatsapp API to leverage the Whatsapp Business Platform API outreach mechanisms

Comparison Whatsapp tool conclusion

	Personal WhatsApp	Business App	Business Platform
Best fit	Personal communication	Low-volume manual one-to-one	Integrated, proactive, multi-agent or at-scale messaging
Main strength	Simple individual use	Business profile and manual tools	CRM/API integration, templates, shared controls and analytics
Main limitation	Not an enterprise business channel	Limited governance and orchestration	Requires onboarding, implementation and ongoing operations
Project position	Do not select as target state	Interim or narrow use case	Default for enterprise integrated messaging
Key restrictions	Personal use only unless otherwise authorized. Bulk messaging, auto-messaging and unauthorized Non-personal use are prohibited	Business opt-in and opt-out obligations apply. Messaging remains manual, with limited native integration and no centralized administration.	Business initiation requires approved templates. Free-form replies are limited to the 24-hour customer service window after the user's last message.

Restriction / blocking exposure	High blocking exposure for proactive business outreach. Account behaviour and user reports can lead to temporary or permanent suspension.	Not a safeguard against blocking. Repeated unwanted contact, spam-like behaviour or policy violations can still trigger enforcement.	More controlled, but not risk-free. WhatsApp may reject or pause templates and limit or remove access for policy violations.
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/!\ Important: moving from Personal WhatsApp to the Business App changes the identity and available tools, but it does not remove WhatsApp's consent, anti-spam or enforcement rules. The Business Platform adds governed outbound mechanisms; it does not guarantee immunity from restriction. /!\

✓ WhatsApp best practices :

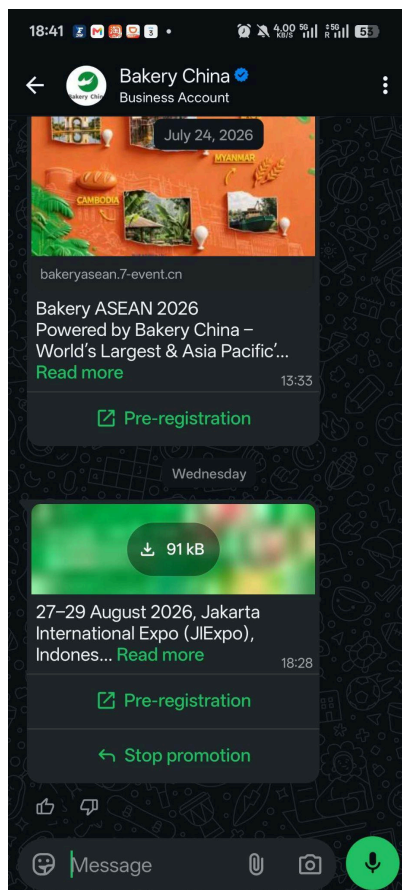
- **Capture explicit consent:** Record the source, date, purpose and channel; explain what the client will receive.
- **Prefer client-initiated entry points.** Use an SA QR code, a short link or a 'Chat with my advisor' action where possible.
- **Identify the sender immediately.** State the brand, store and SA name, and reference the existing client relationship.
- **Keep outreach personal and relevant.** Use client context, vary the wording and limit follow-ups when there is no response.
- **Use the correct messaging mechanism.** On the Business Platform, use an approved template for business initiation or outside the 24-hour service window.
- **Make opt-out easy and immediate.** Treat 'STOP' or any clear refusal as an opt-out and synchronize the preference with the CRM.
- **Keep company ownership and oversight.** Use company-controlled numbers and devices, retain history and monitor restrictions, blocks and reports.

✗ WhatsApp practices not recommended :

- **Do not rely on the phone number alone.** A purchase, contact record or saved number is not evidence of WhatsApp opt-in.
- **Do not scale a new account abruptly.** Avoid repeated copy-paste outreach, rapid follow-ups or many first contacts from a new number or device.
- **Do not use personal WhatsApp as the enterprise target.** Avoid unofficial automation, browser extensions or tools that imitate bulk sending.
- **Do not send vague or misleading openings.** Avoid generic promotional messages that omit the sender, brand, context or reason for contact.
- **Do not ignore negative signals.** Stop outreach after opt-out, repeated delivery failures, account warnings or a rise in blocks and reports.

- **Do not treat Business App as a blocking workaround.** Changing the app without changing consent, relevance and cadence leaves the main risks in place.
- **Do not bypass Platform controls.** Do not misuse template categories, alter a template's purpose or send free-form outreach outside the allowed window.

Example of Whatsapp Business Platform Template message:



Read more:

Moving towards client-consent - client first action before communication:

<https://apacinsider.digital/why-whatsapp-business-accounts-get-banned-in-apac-and-how-companies-can-stay-compliant/>

Whatsapp Business Optin guide for retail

<https://zithara.ai/blogs/whatsapp-business-opt-ins-guide-for-retail-in-2025>